

Coach speak

Ohio State football coach Jim Tressel stresses service at area appearance.
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SPORTS

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Friday,
March 16,
2007

NCAA TOURNAMENT: OHIO STATE 78, CENTRAL CONNECTICUT STATE 57

Nerves don't show in romp

NEXT UP

WHO: Ohio State vs. Xavier
WHEN: Saturday, 1:10 p.m.
WHERE: Rupp Arena, Lexington, Ky.
TV/RADIO: Channel 19; WEOL 930-AM, WKNR 850-AM

TODAY ON TV

All games on Channel 19
● UNLV vs. Georgia Tech, 12:25 p.m.
● Notre Dame vs. Winthrop, 2:35 p.m.
● Virginia Tech vs. Illinois, 7:10 p.m.
● Kentucky vs. Villanova, 9:30 p.m.

INSIDE

● Duke gets decked, B4

Oden shakes off his butterflies, gets lots of help in opening win

Shaun Bennett
The Chronicle-Telegram

LEXINGTON, Ky. — Ohio State freshman Greg Oden admitted he underestimated how big the NCAA Tournament really is.

Thankfully for the Buckeyes, the 7-foot center proved he could come up just as big, finishing with a game-high 19 points and 10 rebounds as top-seeded Ohio State breezed to a 78-57 victory Thursday night over No. 16 Central Connecticut State in a South regional opener.

"I was definitely nervous," Oden said. "I thought that I could just go out there and play like normal, but it was a lot bigger than I thought."

"It's the NCAA Tournament — it's a big deal." Oden wasn't even needed until the Buckeyes decided to put the game out of reach. The Blue Devils began with a zone defense, choosing to pack in the lane and not allow Oden to hurt them.

Ohio State guards Jamar Butler and Ron Lewis were glad to show them the flaw in that plan. Butler hit a pair of 3-pointers to give the Buckeyes a quick 6-0 lead, then Lewis hit a pair of his own before Butler added a third to make it 17-3.

"It was great," Oden said. "They were hitting a whole bunch of threes so I knew all I had to do was get under the basket and grab some rebounds."

Oden then began putting on a power-dunk clinic — throwing down three monster two-handed slams that had the partisan Buckeye crowd oohing and aahing. Lewis got in on the action with a two-handed jam off a Mike Conley Jr. alley-oop pass and followed it with a break-away dunk a minute later.

See OSU, B5



Ohio State center Greg Oden is all smiles as he slams the ball through the hoop during Thursday's game against Central Connecticut State at Rupp Arena in Lexington, Ky.

AP

INDIANS

GM Shapiro signs on for 5 more years

Chris Assenheimer
The Chronicle-Telegram

WINTER HAVEN, Fla. — Everybody's favorite day arrived Thursday for Indians general manager Mark Shapiro — pay day.

In a move that had been anticipated since the opening of training camp, ownership presented Shapiro with a five-year contract extension that will keep the 39-year-old GM in Cleveland through the 2012 season.

According to both parties, the deal had been complete since the opening of camp, with the official announcement coming during a news conference at Chain of Lakes Park prior to the Indians' exhibition game against the Devil Rays.

"This is a great moment for our franchise," said team president Paul Dolan, son of owner Larry Dolan. "This franchise has gone from the bottom to what we consider the top in a record amount of time. By rights, a team in the market of our size, we should be mired in our fourth and fifth year of losing with three or four years ahead of us of losing."

See SHAPIRO, B10



Shapiro

BASEBALL: BOWIE KUHN DIES

Oversaw game's biggest changes

Ronald Blum
The Associated Press

Bowie Kuhn was baseball's bespectacled Ivy League lawyer and looked the part every day of the tumultuous 15 years he ruled as commissioner.

Prim and proper with wire-rim glasses, he stood ramrod straight — all 6-foot-5 of him. Detractors called him a "stuffed shirt" and "pompous," labels that amused him.

Despite his regal bearing, he was as ornery as the owners and players he feuded with over a span that became the second-longest tenure among nine commissioners.

Kuhn, who oversaw the sport's transformation to a business of free agents with multimillion-dollar contracts, died Thursday at St. Luke's Hospital in Jacksonville, Fla., following a short bout with pneumonia that led to respiratory failure, spokesman Bob Wirz said. Kuhn, who was 80, had been hospitalized for several weeks.

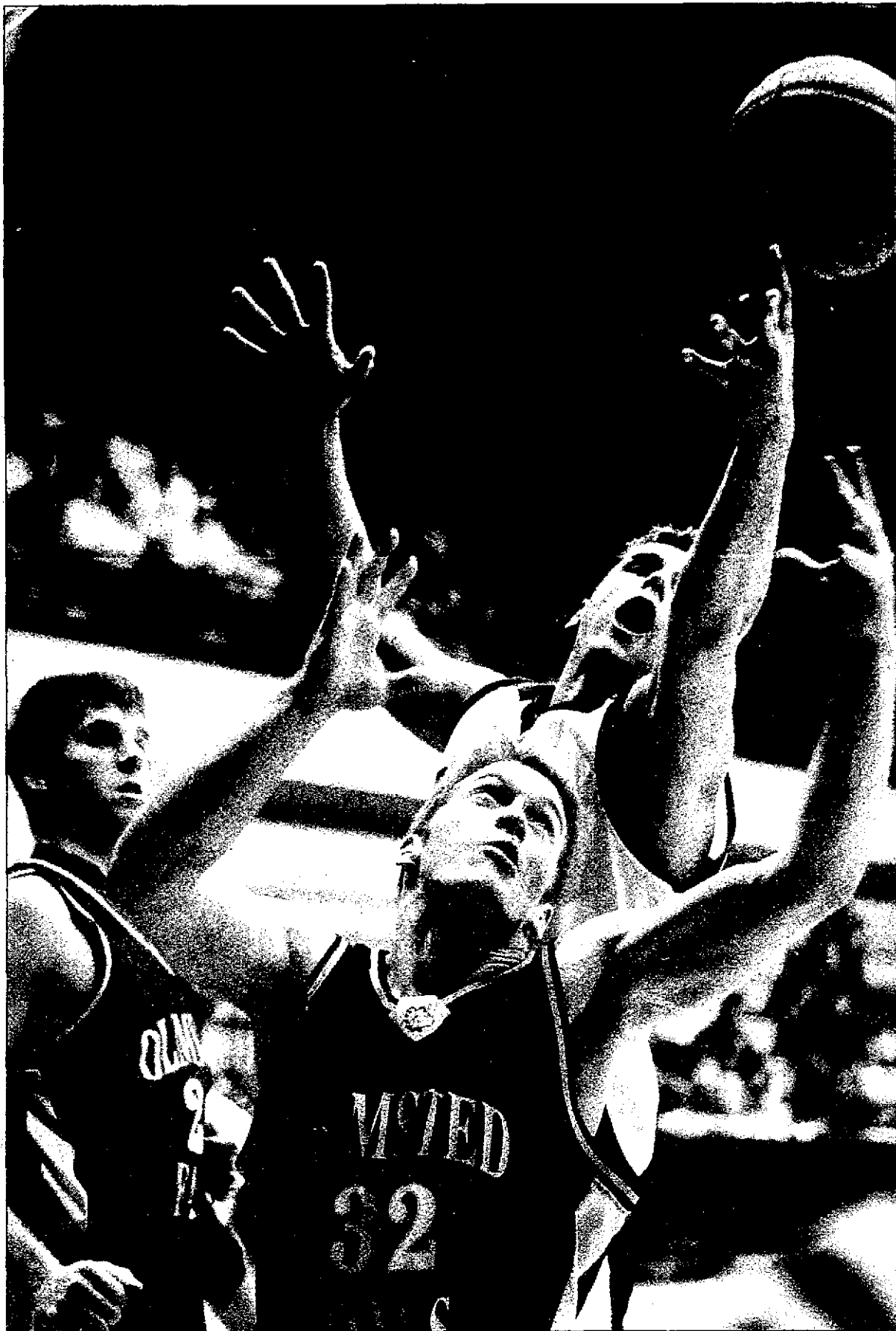
See KUHN, B10



Kuhn

THE TOURNAMENT TRAIL: BOYS REGIONAL BASKETBALL

Sparks ignites Falls



Olmsted Falls' Alex Sedlay grabs a rebound away from Kenmore's Sinisa Srbijan in the third quarter of Thursday's Division II regional semifinal in Canton. Falls advanced to Saturday's final with a 58-48 win.

STEVE MANHEIM / CHRONICLE

Bomb beats buzzer, lifts 'Dogs to win

Steve Byrne
The Chronicle-Telegram

CANTON — Very little was going right for Olmsted Falls in the third period.

The Bulldogs saw a 10-point halftime lead trimmed to one point as Akron Kenmore opened the second half by scoring the first nine points.

But when Tyler Sparks knocked down a shot from the backcourt line at the buzzer ending the third period, giving Olmsted Falls an eight-point cushion, suddenly all looked right for Falls.

"It was lucky, that's for sure," said Sparks of his shot. "It was a good momentum-changer."

Indeed it was. Olmsted Falls scored the first four points of the fourth quarter and didn't let Kenmore get closer than nine the rest of the game en route to a 58-48 victory in regional semifinal play Thursday at Canton Fieldhouse.

The victory lifts eighth-ranked Olmsted Falls (22-2) into the Toledo regional final Saturday against Upper Sandusky, a winner over Van Wert on Thursday. Tip-off for the championship game is 3 p.m. at The University of Toledo's Savage Hall.

Sparks' shot to close the third quarter, coming 4.9 seconds after Kenmore's Aaron Mills missed two free throws, might have been luck, but little else in Sparks' game was a matter of chance. The Bulldogs' 6-foot-4 all-state senior scored 19 points, grabbed 17 rebounds and dished out five assists.

He was especially huge in the third period. Sparks scored eight of Falls' 11 points in the quarter and assisted on a 3-pointer by Kyle Bungard.

"That's why he's All-Ohio," Falls coach Pat Donahue said. "He's been doing that all year. He did the same things in the (district tournament) games against Vermilion and Holy Name."

See FALLS, B2

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